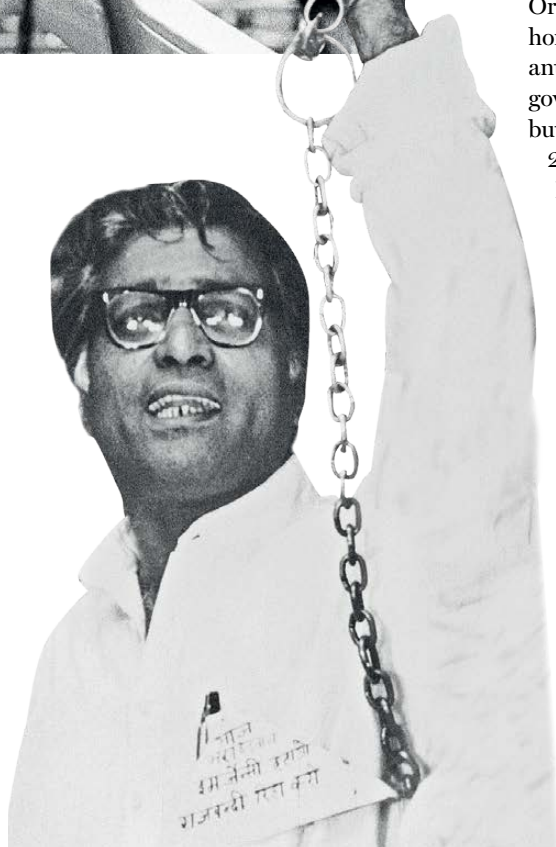


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INDIA TODAY ARCHIVES

**CHAIN REACTION**
George Fernandes, then a firebrand labour leader, is arrested in the Baroda Dynamite Case, Jun. 1976

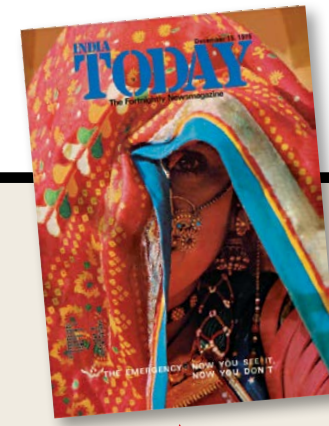
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**The 21 months of extra-parliamentary rule by PM Indira Gandhi** have long been enshrined as the 'dark days of Emergency' in both official cliché and journalese. This notorious episode got its own official anniversary last year when home minister Amit Shah announced that June 25 would henceforth be commemorated as 'Samvidhan Hatya Divas' (roughly 'Constitution Assassination Day'). And earlier this year the Semicentennial was marked by the release of a political melodrama, *Emergency*, produced by the tempestuous Bollywood star Kangana Ranaut. Yet, in retrospect, this chapter of our political history can seem both overdramatised and under-examined.

While, for obvious reasons, the Emergency is often characterised as a period of 'dictatorship' or even 'fascism', Mrs Gandhi did prove a somewhat underwhelming despot by the standards of the time. The 1970s were, after all, the heyday of the brutal praetorian regimes of Pinochet, Pol Pot and Idi Amin. Saddam Hussein and Muammar Gaddafi. Or Generals Zia and Suharto, closer to home. The Emergency's aftermath was anti-climactic too: the Janata coalition government began in electoral euphoria, but ended in shambolic infighting in just 29 months—not much longer than the Emergency itself. This was followed by the return of Mrs Gandhi and the Congress Party, seemingly a reversion to India's default dynasty and party of government.

**FOR OBVIOUS REASONS, THE EMERGENCY IS OFTEN CHARACTERISED AS A PERIOD OF 'DICTATORSHIP' OR EVEN 'FASCISM'**

Yet much had changed in the deeper structures of India's polity, and the consequences and reverberations of this rupture still shape the political landscape we know today. The Emergency's immediate postscript ushered in a new phase of coalition politics, allowing a fresh spectrum of leaders and political parties to taste dominance for the first time. And the Emergency itself was an object lesson in the potential for a charismatic leader at the Centre to intimidate the judiciary, media and civil society into placid compliance. ■




**EMERGENCY**
**Now You See it, Now You Don't**
*Dec. 15, 1975*

**"Where Is The Emergency? What a handful would consider suppression, millions of Indians seem to consider emancipation. Whereas six months ago visitors to India heard little else but complaints about the soaring prices, the average person is grateful he can now feed his family. There are few glaring signs of the emergency as most changes are subtle. A television reporter from New York asked in surprise, 'Where are the soldiers? Where are the guns? Where is the emergency?"**